# Before the Discharge Meeting: A Family Conversation About What Mom Needs Next

One conversation to get what everyone has seen and been told onto one page, with one list of questions.

Your brother thinks Mom should come home. Your sister isn't sure. Nobody has said any of it in the same room yet, and each of you has been told something slightly different by a different person in a hallway.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: go into the discharge meeting with one shared picture and one list of questions. It isn't for deciding where Mom goes.

## Who should be there

Mom, if she is able and wants to be; it can happen in her room. Then everyone who will be part of what comes next: the one who visits every afternoon, the one who lives far away and phones at night, the one who keeps the paperwork. If someone is making healthcare decisions with Mom or for her, they belong in the room. Someone who can't come can join by phone or send notes ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

## How to open

Start with a question, not a conclusion, and start with Mom.

- “Mom, they're starting to talk about what happens after you leave here. Before we meet with them, we want to hear what you want and what's on your mind.”
- “Each of us has been told different things by different people. Let's put it all in one place before the meeting.”
- Say what the conversation is for: one shared picture and one list of questions. Say what it isn't for: deciding where she goes or how anything is paid for.

## Say what each of you can do, and can't

One of the questions below asks what each of you can realistically do. The Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide says discharge planners should talk with you about your willingness and ability to provide care, and that it's important to tell them about any limits. Say those limits here first, and let them stand without anyone having to defend them. [1]

## Questions to ask

## Ask Mom

1. What do you want to happen after you leave here, and what's on your mind about it?

2. What do you feel you can do on your own right now, and where would help be welcome?

## Ask each other

1. What has each of us been told, by whom, and on which day? Where do the versions differ?

2. What have you seen Mom do yourself during this stay, and when were you there?

3. What can each of us realistically do in the coming weeks, and what can't we do?

4. Who is making healthcare decisions with Mom or for her, and who should the staff call first?

5. What do we still not know about the care she needs, where it can be provided, her Medicare coverage and the cost?

6. Who will ask each question at the meeting, and who will write down the answer?

## How to write down what was said

Keep Mom's own account separate from what the family has seen and from what the staff have told you. Where two people saw or heard different things, write both and don't settle it. The differences are questions for the meeting.

| WHAT WAS SAID, SEEN OR HEARD | WHO SAID IT | WHERE IT CAME FROM | HEARD OR SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **“I want to go home. I'll manage the way I always have.”** | Mom | Her own words, Tuesday | |
| **We were told she isn't doing stairs in therapy yet.** | Denise | The physical therapist, Monday | Mark understood she had started stairs |
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## One list of questions for the meeting

Start with the questions your family already has. The first three rows are examples; cross out any that aren't yours.

| QUESTION | WHO IT GOES TO | WHO WILL ASK |
|---|---|---|
| **What level of care does Mom need right now?** | The doctor and the care team | |
| **Where can that care be provided after she leaves here?** | The discharge planner | |
| **Is Medicare covering her care here now, and is that expected to change?** | The business office | |
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## What not to decide yet

These depend on answers you don't have yet, from the people who assess her and the people who know her coverage and the costs. Leave them open. Your list of questions is how they get answered.

- Where Mom should go after she leaves.
- Whether going home is realistic.
- How her care will be paid for.
- Who was right.

## What you can decide today

- Who will speak for the family at the meeting, and who will take notes.
- Who will ask each question on the list.
- Who will send the notes to everyone afterwards, including anyone who couldn't be there.

**What this guide doesn't do**

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide where Mom goes, or tell you what the discharge planner will say. It gets your family to one page and one list, with the differences left on it. Nothing here is medical, legal, financial or tax advice.


### Ready for the next step?

Your family has one shared picture now, and one list of questions. The care interview takes that picture through Mom's situation area by area and turns it into a Family Care Profile everyone can read from in the discharge meeting and in any care conversation after it.

**Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›**


**WHERE THIS COMES FROM**


1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers